

MODULE 36 / 40

Downy Woodpecker

Dryobates pubescens

QUICK STATS

Length	5.5 – 6.7 in (14 – 17 cm)
Wingspan	9.8 – 11.8 in (25 – 30 cm)
Weight	0.7 – 1.0 oz (21 – 28 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 1–2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Downy Woodpecker is the smallest woodpecker in North America and one of the most familiar and beloved backyard birds on the continent — a crisp black-and-white sprite, barely larger than a sparrow, that clings acrobatically to suet feeders, sunflower feeders, and the branches of garden trees throughout the year. Its bold pattern — white back stripe, spotted wings, and the male's small red nape patch — makes it immediately recognizable. It is among the most frequent visitors to backyard feeding stations across North America, and its gentle, confiding nature makes it a favorite of beginning and experienced birders alike.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Downy Woodpecker is a year-round resident across most of North America, from Alaska and southern Canada south through the entire contiguous United States. It is absent only from the arid Southwest and treeless grasslands. It inhabits deciduous and mixed forests, woodland edges, orchards, suburban parks, and backyard gardens with mature trees. It is the most widespread woodpecker in North America and one of the few that regularly visits suburban feeders year-round.

DIET & FEEDING

- Insect larvae and beetle grubs excavated from bark and wood
- Suet — the single most reliable feeder attractant for this species
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and sunflower chips
- Ants, caterpillars, and spiders gleaned from bark surfaces
- Wild berries and small fruits taken occasionally
- Sap from sapsucker wells in winter and early spring

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Downy Woodpeckers are among the most acrobatic of feeder birds, clinging to vertical suet cages, hanging from sunflower feeders, and working their way along the undersides of small branches with ease. They use their stiff tail feathers as a prop against bark surfaces — a trait shared with all woodpeckers. Outside the breeding season, Downy Woodpeckers often join mixed foraging flocks with chickadees, nuthatches, and titmice — a strategy that improves predator detection. Males and females partition foraging space: males tend to forage on small branches and weed stems, females on larger trunks and branches.

NESTING & BREEDING

Both sexes excavate a nest cavity in a dead tree or snag, typically 5–50 feet above the ground, over 1–3 weeks. The entrance hole is about 1.25 inches in diameter. No nesting material is added — eggs are laid on wood chips. Clutches of 3–8 white eggs are incubated by both parents for 11–12 days, with the male incubating at night. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 20–25 days. One brood per season. Old cavities are used by many other species.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Downy Woodpecker's most distinctive sound is its "pik" call — a sharp, high-pitched single note given frequently as the bird forages. In spring, both sexes drum on resonant wood to advertise territory and attract mates — a rapid, even roll of about 15 beats per second. The whinny call — a descending, laughing series of notes — is given in territorial encounters. The Downy's drum is faster and higher-pitched than the similar Hairy Woodpecker's.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
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The Downy Woodpecker population is estimated at 14 million individuals in North America and has declined modestly in recent decades, largely due to the loss of dead trees and snags used for nesting. Retaining dead trees and large snags in yards and woodlands is the single most effective conservation action. Suet feeders provide critical winter energy, and planting native trees that host insect larvae supports year-round foraging.

FEEDER TIPS

- Suet in a cage feeder is the top attractant — use year-round
- Sunflower chips and black-oil sunflower seeds also readily taken
- A tail-prop suet cage (open bottom) mimics natural bark foraging posture
- Leave dead branches and snags on trees — essential for nesting and foraging
- Downies are often the first woodpecker to discover a new feeder

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back	White stripe down center — key field mark
Wings	Black with white spots and bars
Head (male)	Black and white with red nape patch
Head (female)	Black and white — no red
Underparts	Clean white
Bill	Short, chisel-shaped, dark gray

COLOR ME!

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